

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Reuters

Shares in **SpaceX** popped on their first day trading on the Nasdaq, valuing the firm at around \$2.1trn—and making its boss, Elon Musk, [the world's first trillionaire](#). The [rocketry and AI firm's](#) shares closed at \$161, around 19% higher than its opening price and peaked at almost \$177 during the day. SpaceX raised \$75bn in a record IPO on Thursday when it sold 555.6m shares at \$135.

Pakistan's prime minister, Shehbaz Sharif, said the final text for a [peace deal](#) between **America** and **Iran** had been reached and that mediators were working with both sides on next steps. He said an “incessant misinformation campaign” had attempted to “sabotage” the agreement. Earlier **Donald Trump** accused Iran of leaking inaccurate terms of the deal. Seyed Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, said details would be shared “in due course”.

Anthropic said it would prevent foreign nationals “whether inside or outside the United States” from using its Fable 5 and Mythos models, including its own foreign employees. The AI lab said it was complying with a directive from the Trump administration, which cited national-security concerns. Anthropic had previously expressed concern that its new models were [too powerful](#) and could be exploited by hackers.

Mr Trump said that American armed forces had “executed” Héctor Guerrero Flores, better known as Niño Guerrero, head of **Tren De Aragua**, a Venezuelan [gang](#). The president said that the airstrike that took out the kingpin had been “co-ordinated closely with our friends in Venezuela”. Mr Guerrero ran the drug and human-trafficking organisation from a prison cell, until his [escape](#) in 2023.

A federal judge extended a block on the creation of Mr Trump’s \$1.8bn “**Anti-Weaponisation Fund**” for [supposed victims of “lawfare”](#). The president has continued to defend the scheme, which faces legal challenges, despite his administration saying it had pulled the plug on it. The judge said the legal case would be dismissed if the government submits a sworn declaration to abandon the fund.

In an effort to address a shortage of troops, **Volodymyr Zelensky**, Ukraine’s president, said the army will raise wages and try to recruit more volunteer fighters from abroad. Monthly wages for most soldiers will increase by a third, to around \$700, while frontline troops will receive about \$7,000 a month. Ukraine’s defence budget is set to grow as instalments from a €90bn (\$104bn) loan from the EU begin to arrive in June.

David Hockney, a British artist, died aged 88. The Yorkshireman [made his name](#) with vibrant acrylic pieces, including “A Bigger Splash”, a painting of a swimming pool beneath a flawless Californian sky, and intimate double portraits such as “Portrait of an Artist”, which became the most expensive picture by a living artist ever sold at auction. King Charles called him “a dear friend and inspiration to so many”.

Word of the week: SaaSocalypse, the widespread ruin that many fear AI will bring to the software-as-a-service industry. [But will it?](#)

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highlights of reader correspondence.



Photograph: AP

South Korea cosies up to Europe

Lee Jae Myung, South Korea's president, is on a whirlwind tour of Europe. This week he held summits in Brussels with the European Union's top leadership and Belgium's prime minister. Then he visited Rome for talks with Italy's prime minister. His next stop is the Vatican, where he will attend mass and meet Pope Leo XIV. Finally, he will travel to France for the G7 summit. Trade, technology and defence have topped the agendas.

Mr Lee has put his country back on track since taking office last year. After the impeachment of his predecessor [for declaring martial law](#), he restored political stability; he has also deftly steered South Korea's diplomacy. In [a recent interview with *The Economist*](#), Mr Lee spoke confidently about moving his country "beyond this normalisation of the abnormal". His talk of developing into a "nation that leads the world" sounds more aspirational. But his current trip does demonstrate South Korea's growing global clout.

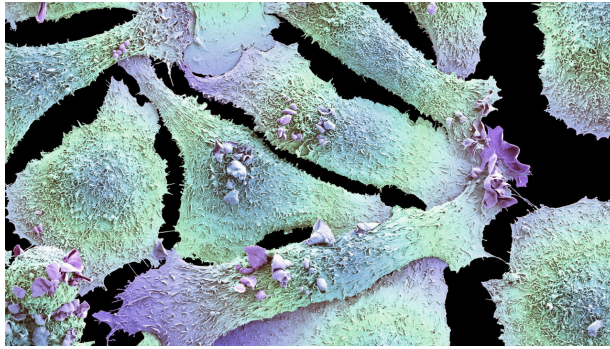


Photograph: Getty Images

The Green Party's next challenge

Britain's Green Party has been on a tear. Under its fiery leader, [Zack Polanski](#), the party has shifted its focus from environmental issues to a broader left-wing populism. It has proposed a sweeping [tax on wealth](#) and adopted a strongly pro-Palestinian stance. The party has risen in [opinion polls](#) from single digits to around 15%; some surveys even put the Greens ahead of the ruling Labour Party.

The party's London branch holds its summer conference this weekend, with Mr Polanski as the headline act. London is a crucial hunting ground: after local elections in May, the Greens now control six of the city's 32 boroughs, either alone or in coalition. Their challenge now is to show they can appeal to voters beyond their ultra-progressive support base: a policy review may well see them ditch their most extreme ideas, such as a commitment to fully open borders.



Photograph: Science Photo Library

A potential new way to prevent lung cancer

Cancer prevention has mostly been about promoting a healthy lifestyle. But new research suggests existing anti-inflammatory drugs [could help prevent lung cancer](#), the most common cancer diagnosis globally.

Scientists have identified a molecular “signature” that predicts a higher risk of the disease. By examining blood samples from nearly 50,000 people in the UK Biobank, a dataset, they found 14 proteins whose levels increased five years or more before diagnosis. This protein signature was validated in eight other datasets around the world.

The proteins were linked to lung inflammation, which can be caused by smoking or air pollution. A signalling molecule in the inflammation process called interleukin-1 beta (IL-1 β) can activate dormant cancer-causing mutations in lung cells. Drugs that block IL-1 β already exist for other conditions. When scientists reanalysed trial data for one such drug called canakinumab, they found it nearly halved the risk of lung cancer among people with high levels of the 14 proteins. The next step is to develop a commercial test for detecting the signature.



Photograph: Universal Studios

Steven Spielberg has more to say about aliens

The secret is out in [“Disclosure Day”](#), Steven Spielberg’s new sci-fi blockbuster, released in cinemas this week. In the frantic, occasionally baffling story, Daniel (Josh O’Connor) is a cyber-whizz who swipes an archive of the American government’s clandestine contacts with aliens. He is pursued by Wardex, a shadowy agency. Meanwhile Margaret (Emily Blunt), a TV meteorologist, is suddenly able to speak many languages and divine strangers’ intimate thoughts. Oh, and the world is on the brink of nuclear war.

“Disclosure Day” features many of Mr Spielberg’s familiar motifs, not least John Williams’s swelling music. But it most closely recalls “Close Encounters of the Third Kind” (1977). Once again the authorities conceal the truth about extraterrestrials; and again the underlying theme is communication, between people and countries. As he so often does, the great director may leave you feeling on the verge of tears without really knowing why.



Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Aiko, the princess barred from the Japanese throne

At New Year Emperor Naruhito and his family stepped onto a balcony at the Imperial Palace in Tokyo. Thousands of well-wishers waved Japanese flags and cheered. But it was 24-year-old Aiko, or Princess Toshi, who made the crowd swoon. As if awaiting a pop idol, some held fans emblazoned with her name.

Aiko is the emperor's only child. But she can never inherit the throne: [succession is restricted to men](#) and only passes through the male line. When she marries, Aiko will leave the imperial family and become a commoner.

That is a problem for the family. Japan's monarchy, the world's oldest, is running out of heirs. In recent decades royal men have fathered several girls but only one boy: 19-year-old Prince Hisahito, Naruhito's nephew. If he does not father a son, the 2,700-year-old imperial line will die out.

Aiko's popularity has encouraged more Japanese to think that should change. From a young age she showed public-spiritedness. As a schoolgirl she wrote a story about a nurse who heals injured animals. After college she worked for the Red Cross. Her public appearances have impressed people, too; during her first official overseas visit, to Laos in 2025, she clung to a toy elephant a sick child had given her, refusing to pass it to an aide. And many

Japanese regret the intense scrutiny her mother, Masako, faced for failing to produce an heir.

Japan's politicians are acutely aware. On June 10th leaders from the main political parties approved a proposal to amend the Imperial House Law to allow female royals to remain in the family after marriage. It would also enable royals to adopt children from imperial branch families that were stripped of royal status following the second world war (though they will not have succession rights). But the changes will still not let women rule.

Polls suggest that 90% of Japanese support a female emperor. Last year the country [elected its first female prime minister](#), Takaichi Sanae. And there is even a comic-book series that argues for Aiko to become monarch. But Japan is still ranked 27th of 29 countries in *The Economist's* [glass-ceiling index](#), which measures how women fare in the workplace. It may be a while yet before a woman sits on the Chrysanthemum Throne.

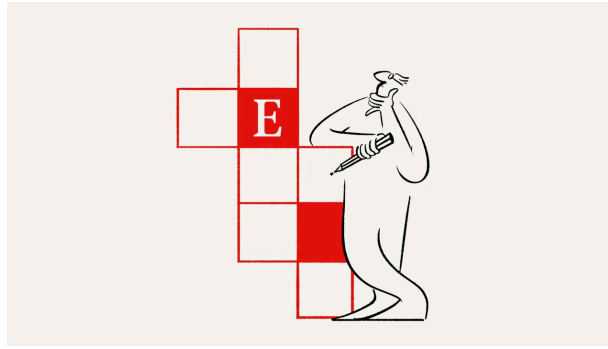


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - South-west makes way for HR in sorrow, disgust (6)

2 across - Voyage the first time roads are vacant, evading lawlessness (6)

3 across - Hesitation after abnormal baby prattle (6)

1 down - Out of place, I spit at holy, warm reception (11)

Straight clues

1 across - _ show, _ film, _ -struck – scary! (6)

2 across - It usually requires many steps, but in basketball it only needs two or three (6)

3 across - Australian chatter (6)

1 down - The Greek concept “Xenia” that Zeus loved to test on humans (11)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Cheryl Bernhardt, Calgary, Canada

Lungile Thabo Twalo, Johannesburg, South Africa

Kathryn Voegeli, Uetikon am See, Switzerland

They gave the correct answers of Monterrey, Vancouver, Philadelphia, Guadalajara and Atlanta. The theme is they are all venues for the 2026 football World Cup, which began this week.

The questions were

Monday: What is the capital of the Mexican state of Nuevo León?

Tuesday: Stanley Park is a large public park in which North American city?

Wednesday: The First Continental Congress met in 1774 in which city?

Thursday: What is the capital of the Mexican state of Jalisco?

Friday: Which us city has the busiest airport in the world, in terms of passenger traffic?

*No intelligent idea can gain
general acceptance unless some
stupidity is mixed in with it.*

Fernando Pessoa